

THE TELESCOPE

Telescopium



SIZE RANKING 57

BRIGHTEST STAR Alpha (α) 3.5

GENITIVE Telescopii

ABBREVIATION Tel

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM July–August

FULLY VISIBLE 33°N–90°S

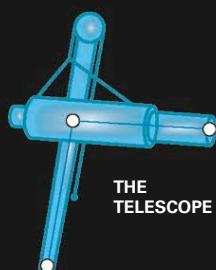


Telescopium is an almost entirely undistinguished southern constellation near Sagittarius and Corona Australis. It was invented by the French astronomer Nicolas Louis de Lacaille (see p.422) to commemorate the telescope. Its pattern of stars represents one of the aerial telescopes used at the Paris observatory. These

were refractors with extremely long focal lengths—to reduce chromatic aberration—suspended from tall poles by ropes and pulleys.

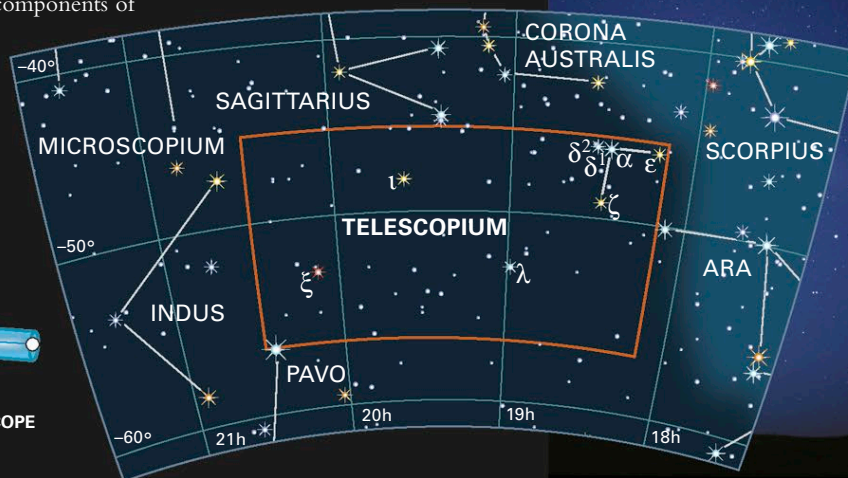
SPECIFIC FEATURES

Delta (δ) Telescopii is an unrelated pair of stars with components of 5th magnitude. It can be divided with binoculars or even good eyesight.



LONG VIEW

Telescopium depicts an early design of refracting telescope with a long tube supported by a flimsy mounting—a far cry from the massive reflectors of today.



THE INDIAN

Indus



SIZE RANKING 49

BRIGHTEST STAR Alpha (α) 3.1

GENITIVE Indi

ABBREVIATION Ind

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 PM August–October

FULLY VISIBLE 15°N–90°S



This southern constellation was introduced in the late 16th century by Pieter Dirkszoon Keyser and Frederick de Houtman (see panel, right). It represents a human figure

with a spear and arrows, although it remains unclear whether this is supposed to be a native of the East Indies (as discovered by the Dutch explorers during their expeditions) or a native of the Americas.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Fifth-magnitude Epsilon (ε) Indi is one of the closest stars to us, being 11.8 light-years away. Somewhat smaller and cooler than the Sun, it appears pale orange in color.

Theta (θ) Indi is a 4th-magnitude star with a companion of 7th magnitude that can be identified through a small telescope.

CONCEALED FIGURE

Only a vivid imagination could discern the figure of a human in the constellation of Indus, which comprises a few faint stars next to the distinctive figures of Grus and Tucana.

EXPLORING SPACE

DUTCH VOYAGES OF DISCOVERY

As well as exploring the southern oceans, Dutch traders and navigators charted the southern sky. On the first Dutch expedition to the East Indies in 1595 were two Dutch navigator–astronomers, Pieter Dirkszoon Keyser (c. 1540–1596) and Frederick de Houtman (1571–1627). Keyser died during the voyage, but his celestial observations, along with those of de Houtman, were returned to the Dutch cartographer Petrus Plancius (see p.358) and formed the basis for 12 new constellations, all of which are still recognized.

FAMILY OF EXPLORERS

The first Dutch expedition to the East Indies consisted of four ships and was led by Cornelis de Houtman, the brother of Frederick, who was on the trip as a navigator.

